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SOME OBSERVATIONS ON RECENT REPORTED UNDERGRADUATE
CONVERSIONS TO CHRISTIANITY.

According to the papers there have been fresh instances lately of the conversion of Jewish undergraduates to Christianity. One understands on enquiry that the cases are after all very few and that they have taken place, almost entirely, in the old residential Universities, and in them there are certain special conditions which do not obtain elsewhere. The "loss" therefore, if loss it be, is quantitatively slight and restricted to a small area. At the same time it is not unimportant, and it calls for reflection and study. The purpose of this paper is to bring some of the points into public discussion, and to dismiss some others.

I should make a few remarks by way of preliminary. The phenomenon is not unique. We have all heard of the alleged movement towards Catholicism, for example, in England; and I note from the Times of 27 March 1954 that, according to the estimate of an American Protestant magazine, more than four million Catholics in the United States were converted to Protestantism during the past ten years (as against a million odd from Protestantism to Catholicism). These last figures have been questioned and are possibly exaggerated; but they do bear witness (and that is my point at the moment) to the existence of shifts in personal religious adhesion. I should have you note too that the figures, even if discounted, are high, and represent much heart-burning and family distress. It may well be that conversion from Judaism to Christianity is something more drastic than movements within the bounds of Christianity itself. But the point is that there are changes of

belief among men and we should accept the fact.

Now religion is a serious thing. We may not be what is called religious ourselves; but we should at least recognise the possibility that, if a person adopts a religion he was not born into, he shows a living, and presumably a sincere, interest in religion as such. Whatever we do, therefore, we dare not scoff. We are in the presence of a serious matter demanding a sincere interest from all serious and sincere persons. I cut out therefore at once all the conventional terms of disapprobation (if not abuse) which are often used in this connexion. There may be among the conversions cases of social climbing or of bending to social pressure; of the desire for self-accommodation or easy living; of a passion for self-assertion or of plain exhibitionism; even of mere slackness and don't-care-ism. Such cases (and for all I know they may be the majority) we may for our present purpose ignore. For they are not the only cases and they are not, for us at the moment, the important cases. The cases I wish to direct your attention to here are those of genuine conviction. It may be humiliating to us, but we have to face the fact that there are people born in the Jewish community (and more immediately undergraduate members of the universities, i.e., presumably men and women of high training and good education) who, having sought, find in Christianity what they do not find in Judaism. It may be that they seek what they should not seek, or that they do not find what they should find. That we shall have to consider. But we must accept the possibility of the existence of an honest conviction that Judaism does not serve their need whilst Christianity does.

2.

I said we must avoid the usual reproaches and expressions of contempt

with which this matter is generally met in our community. I add that together with opprobrious terms, we shall have to jettison a number of well-known attitudes and arguments. There is for example the attitude of the High Horse School.

The High Horse School says: "Why worry? If they drop away, let them. The very fact of their dropping off like poor apples shows that they are no good". I confess to some sympathy with this School. They are like the inveterate pruners among gardeners: stern and severe men who care to produce only the best.

Yet for all that I do not think they are wise. Even in gardens there is room for the second-rate. And there are many people who like myself are glad of the droppings from the apple trees: the apples that stay on often get wormy. It is a sufficient criticism of the High Horse School that their own products are not always of the highest quality. I should say of the High Horse School in general what was said of the unreformed House of Lords: "If you incline to admire them, go and look at them!"

Then there is the Nationalist School. The Nationalist School says: "But you can't do that. What will become of the Jews?" The would-be convert has an easy reply to that, and that is: "Why should I care?"; and we must realise that this reply, whether flippant or serious, has received notable and weighty corroboration in our time. It has been well put (if I understand him aright) by a very distinguished and sought-after member of the Jewish community who in a recent essay which attracted much attention averred that the significance for the non-Israeli Jew of the coming-into-being of the State of Israel is that it gives him honourable ground for abdication. He can (as it were) now say: "Up till now I have

remained a Jew because I considered that the honour of the Jew, and the survival of Jewry, depended to some real, however small, extent upon my remaining within the Jewish fold. Nowadays the honour of the Jew, and the survival of Jewry, is in other and stronger and more permanent hands, the hands of the State of Israel. I can therefore permit myself to make my bow and depart; and I do so freely and without loss of self-respect. I will my way out of a historic community because its history no longer depends on me. My conscience is clear. Thy servant departs in peace!

The Nationalist School therefore would seem to have no longer a conclusive, that is, a final appeal. Nor, and for the same reason, has the Pathetic School. The Pathetic School asks plaintively: "How can you leave the poor and despised Jews?" Again the answer is the State of Israel: there surely is a strong arm and a mighty hand. The Jews in fact (or so we are told by the propagandists) have ceased to be poor and despised. They have a flourishing land of their own.

In another class altogether I place the Text Disputation School. This has a very respectable history from the very earliest times and has a very considerable literary interest of its own. But I fancy that, so far as we are concerned, it is largely out of date. I don't think many (if any) of us allow our religious beliefs to be determined by the proper translation of a word in the 7th chapter of Isaiah.

And the same may be said of the kindred Anti-Dogmatic School: nineteenth century Rationalism is no longer in fashion. The old argumentation against certain articles of the Athanasian Creed has lost much of its force in our day. For one reason these dogmas, although

retained and adhered to by the Church, are interpretable, and are interpreted, in more acceptable ways than a century ago. They are not in fact as simple as they look; nor is their 'refutation' simple. Second, and more important, there has been a remarkable shift in Christian theology in the last fifty years from metaphysics to psychology, a shift well expressed in the title of the great work which marked and typified the change, James' Varieties of Religious Experience. This stress on experience rather than on creeds has been used to evade many of the old difficulties and it has been made to cover many features otherwise intractable. We cannot do what our great-grandfathers did: call the doctrine of the Trinity bad arithmetic and imagine that thereby Christianity is dismissed.

With all this out of the way -- that is, remember, most of the accepted approach to the problem -- we may turn to the essence. I revert then, to my original point. We must recognise the existence of a religious need, a need to which the new religion is believed to give satisfaction, the old religion not.

3.

And please don't tell me triumphantly that Judaism is not a religion and that therefore the whole question falls. It is really in that assertion that the whole question consists. Indeed, I am not sure that in many cases it is not from that assertion that the whole question has not arisen. For the honest convert (and we are assuming that there are such) is interested precisely in religion; and if Judaism is not a religion, there is no reason he can see for him to remain a Jew. I suggest we drop

all that and ask ourselves what, according to men of religion, religion really is; what in fact is the felt need, and why do some Jews go outside Judaism to assuage it.

I wonder whether any of you has read the Gide-Claudé correspondence. Gide, as you know, was a sceptical, some would say a non-believing, Protestant; Claudé, from the day of his conversion at the age of eighteen after reading -- of all people -- Rimbaud, was an eloquent and fighting Catholic. The interest of the correspondence lies in the passionate way in which Claudé tried to influence his friend to become a 'real' Christian, i.e., to enter the Catholic Church. He goes to the attack -- and it is an attack -- again and again. He is all conviction, and he feels his function to lie in the struggle to convince others. Rimbaud, he says, gave him the sense of the unseen; and it is the 'sense of the unseen' (not a bad first definition of religion) which he is trying to instill, or rather to awaken, in the mind and in the heart of his friend. For Jews there is a passage of special significance in a letter of September 1913 written while Claudé was on holiday in the south of France: "I have found here", he says, "some really beautiful souls -- a young Jew, an old Polish lady. The need which people have of God to-day is a truly astonishing thing. As soon as they feel themselves in the presence of a sincere believer and as soon as they are able to overcome their timidity, one perceives, by the confessions they make to you, that the privation of God is, for a very large number of people whom one believed indifferent, a cause of profound suffering. What a dreadful pity to allow oneself thus to die of hunger when there is bread for all!"

4.

You might say that's slop. It is not. It reaches the heart of the matter. Rightly or wrongly, and especially now, people are sick to death of being told of the triumphs and beauties of science. There is a yearning for something else, a something far more personal and intimate, something which will lead not to physical disruption and world destruction, but to spiritual harmony both for individuals and for man as such. That something else may be sought for in art, in music, in poetry; even, by the tough-minded, in philosophy. The more tender-minded --- and I am using the phrase neither ironically nor scornfully: there are people on this earth who are not professional philosophers --- the more tender-minded (and I say again that by tender-minded I do not mean weak-minded) may well seek it in religion. It may be envisaged as a razor's edge or as a feather bed; but the seeking -- and often the finding -- is a fact. There is a famous preface of F.H. Bradley in which he says that for him the religious urge turned to metaphysics. I should imagine that for most men the metaphysical urge, the urge to come to terms with the universe, turns to religion. And it is little to the point to breathe the blessed word sublimation, or to invoke the Oedipus complex. Whatever the cause may be, there exists in man a desire to worship, and find fulfilment in, something which is not the product of his own hands, be that product even so awe-inspiring as an electronic brain or a hydrogen bomb. To put it very crudely and using purely intellectual terms (and religion is neither crude nor a matter of the pure intellect): We make the hydrogen bomb and we know we make it; what we want to know (in so far as it is a question of knowledge) is who made us. To put it

a little less crudely: The things we value and strive for point to a perfection beyond ourselves which we would fain draw near to, and enter into relations with, for our very soul's sake. Even the typical scientist's vision of the universal harmony is, empirically speaking, a vision, not a fact.

Miss Kathleen Nott has just written a provoking and entertaining book on the literary man's habit of abusing the scientist in the interests of religion. It is called *The Emperor's Clothes*, and I advise you all to read it. There was also a striking pronouncement in the *Hibbert Journal* for January (1954) by Mr. A.L. Routh of All Souls on the quarrel between religion and science in which the point is made that the trouble with religion is that, overlaid as it is with dogma, it denies within its own domain the right of free enquiry which is the essence both of science and of modern civilisation. As I read both of these contributions to the old debate I was struck by the fact that on the grounds they premised Judaism suffers much less severely than Christianity. For example, the theological dogma of Original Sin which is the bane of Miss Nott does not, in the Christian sense, exist for Judaism; while it is one of peculiarities of Judaism that, far from finding difficulties in the enlargement of science, in its best period it not only encouraged but even embraced it. But I am not concerned now with that ancient topic. I am concerned simply to point out that Judaism, and in this it is the prototype of all religion, is essentially and primarily a concern with the first and last things, with what Claudel calls the unseen. Claudel, the ardent Catholic, was talking to Gide, the

sceptical Protestant, with the authentic voice of the mother-religion of both Catholicism and Protestantism.

I shall come to differences in a moment but they are surely on a ground of agreement: the differences are as nothing compared with the positions held in common. And that brings me to my main point. I wonder at times whether the converts are not being converted, not to Christianity at all but to Judaism.

5.

That is a paradox and an intentional one. I have ventured on it in order to emphasise what is so important to grasp but which few seem to notice: in our day Jews become converted to Christianity because our leaders (especially our religious leaders) and our public orators seem to have forgotten what Judaism is. Judaism (dare I say it?) is a doctrine of God. On its intellectual side it is a certain view about the constitution of things, a view which asserts their origin in, and dependance on, God. It then goes on to affirm, as a consequence, a certain way of living for man and to assert that a certain people, under pains and penalties (often, alas, forgotten), was appointed to exemplify that way. But it starts with God, 'the first and the last': 'In the beginning God created'. Judaism is in fact a theology in the literal sense, a 'logos', i.e. a reasoned account, of 'theos', God. All the rest is commentary.

It is because we have forgotten this (I suggest) that some Jews in despair have sought for it in Christianity. But I think I have shocked you sufficiently. Let us turn to conventional apologetics. Do they

contain any helpful ideas? I should say very few. Indeed I think that it will all have to be done over again and in the light of other principles altogether. I shall offer an instance or two.

6.

I am almost ashamed to mention the doctrine of equal inspiration for every Biblical word; but one still hears the triumphant production of Maimonides' dictum: "'Hear O Israel' and 'the sister of Lotan was Timna' came equally from the mouth of the Most High", as if it meant that the two sentences were of equal importance. I do not think that Maimonides meant that; but if he did, he should not have. As a former colleague of mine in Jerusalem was inspired to write in a newspaper article: "Akiba at the stake did not cry out with his last breath: 'And the sister of Lotan was Timna.'" We have to accept once for all the fact (which is in any case obvious) that there are found in the Hebrew Bible expressions of different levels of maturity. Of these levels, often indicated by the Bible itself, it is our duty to choose the higher. We do not follow David in his measuring out the Moabites with a line and destroying two lengths and preserving one, but in his recognition of, and prayer for, moral change. This treatment of the Bible is nothing out-of-the-way or extraordinary. It is exactly what every sensible person has always done with any literature. It is certainly what the Talmudic authorities did with the Bible and we have the right and duty to follow them.

For (second) neither inspiration nor wisdom ceased with the closing of the Canon, as they were not exhausted with the books of the Canon. There is an oral as well as a written Torah; and the oral ante-dated, as

it also post-dated, the written. Judaism is based on the Hebrew Bible, but it had a continued and developing life both during the Biblical period and in the Rabbinical writings. Rabbinical Judaism is a guide, and in many respects an admirable guide, both for the treatment of sources and for our own attitudes and actions. Chronologically covering (tho' it is of course more extensive than) the growth and systematisation of Christian theory and practice, it offers an alternative to the other development of Biblical Judaism which was shaped (it may be, mis-shaped) by Jesus, Paul and the Church Fathers. This conception should be the basis of argument with the would-be convert, if argument there is to be. Whoever wishes to follow the Christian road should be shown the alternative, the Jewish, i.e., (primarily) the Rabbinic; and the first task of our scholars is to rescue the word Rabbinic from the disrepute into which it has been allowed to fall.

In the meantime ordinary people like ourselves should study and popularise the use of George Foot Moore's Judaism (Harvard University Press, 1927) and rejoice that the work has been so well done for us by a non-Jew. But in any case let us press home the idea of an alternative. Granted development, granted new circumstances and new needs, why not study, we should say, what Rabbinical Judaism really was instead of accepting and rejecting what it is currently and wrongly supposed to have been. Why not see how the Bible was used by them and how thus a normative Judaism was created. (I have just seen Dr. James Parkes' lecture The Concept of a Chosen People in Judaism and Christianity where he makes a very similar suggestion. I recommend everybody to try to get this and study it. Dr. Parkes' Judaism and Christianity, which expounds

his views at greater length, is to be found in most Public Libraries).

If we can press home the idea of the existence of the Rabbinic development as an alternative to the Christian, the question will arise why follow the one in preference to the other. Then is the time for polemic, i.e., the weighing - the respectful weighing - of the one against the other. But here too there is truth and falsity. It is false to denigrate the person of Jesus. We must allow the truth that he was an extraordinary man. And it is ridiculous - and I personally think disastrous - to do what Ahad Ha'am tried to do, to make out that the moral teaching of Jesus was something un-Jewish. On this point Klausner is much more sound, and even, for that matter, Sholem Asch. It is not for nothing that every phrase and almost every word of the parables and dicta of Jesus can be paralleled in Rabbinic writings. Translate them into Hebrew and they sound like ordinary Aggada; and like ordinary Aggada they are a legitimate expression of opinion to be judged on its merits which, in this case, should be judged very high.

But it should be insisted that it is possible to admire the figure of Jesus and yet not only not be or become a Christian, but also remain a Jew. The decisive departure from Judaism lies not in the claim that God can be reached through Jesus - God can be reached through the help and wisdom and illumination of many sages and prophets - but in the claim that it is only through Jesus that God can be reached at all. It is that 'only' which is the trouble. We may agree that Jesus was a great and good man, possibly one of the greatest and best. But there were others; and it is to be hoped that there will be yet others to come. So we can not agree that it is in principle only through him that man can

reach God; and that is one vital point on which we should be clear to ourselves and try to make clear to others.

7.

Another vital point is the doctrine of the Atonement, however it be presented and interpreted. Here again one should rightly be respectful. 'Do not revile the gods of other people' is a sturdy piece of ancient Jewish theological good manners. But we should point out firmly that the Jewish doctrine is one of personal responsibility -- 'he who has sinned will I blot out from my book' -- and that no external sacrifice blots out sin, even in the sinner himself. The whole theory of sacrifice requires explanation, and the simplest explanation is the plain text of the Pentateuch itself:

'And the Lord spake unto Moses saying, If anyone sin, and commit a trespass against the Lord, and deal falsely with his neighbour in a matter of deposit, or of bargain, or of robbery, or have oppressed his neighbour; or have found that which was lost and deal falsely therein and swear to a lie; in any of all these that a man doeth, sinning therein; Then it shall be, if he hath sinned and is guilty, that he shall restore that which he took by robbery, or the thing which he hath gotten by oppression, or the deposit which was committed to him, or the lost thing which he found, or any thing about which he hath sworn falsely; he shall even restore it in full, and shall add the fifth part more thereto; unto him to whom it appertaineth shall he give it in the day of his being found guilty. And he shall bring his guilt offering unto the Lord, etc.' (Lev. vi, 1-7)

I am sorry to inflict so long a quotation on you, but it illumines a central point. According to the clear statement of the priestly code itself, sacrifice atones for nothing. The sinner has to redeem his sin himself, and that can be done only by practical restitution. The sacrifice comes afterwards, after the act of practical restitution (plus one fifth by way of indemnity), as a public ~~acknowledgement~~ of the wrong

done and now redeemed. I shall not worry you with the Rabbinical variations on this central theme. If the voice of Judaism speaks clearly on anything, it is on this. As for human sacrifice, it was repudiated once for all in the typical case of Isaac. (I have never understood why we speak of the sacrifice of Isaac. The whole point of the story is that the sacrifice did not come off.) We are rightly proud of the famous declaration of the duties of man in the prophet Micah: 'He hath told thee, O man, what is good'; but we should remember that it was given in answer to the question: 'Shall I give my firstborn for my transgression?'

On this point of doctrine there can be no compromise. But I see no reason why men should not agree to differ, provided, that is, they know what it is they are differing about. My own impression, formed by listening to people discussing our general theme, is that most of us do not know what we are differing about.

8.

Incidentally, I think it is most urgent that educated Jews should know more of the early history of anti-Jewish propaganda, especially in the writings of the earliest Church fathers at the time when the Church was struggling to emancipate itself from the Synagogue. (An interesting account is to be found in Harnack's Mission and Expansion of Christianity.) It was the virulence generated at this epoch which was the prime source of the hatred of Judaism and Jewry which became part of the general cultural inheritance of Europe and which accounts for most of the views current to this very day on the nature of Judaism, views which the would-be convert absorbs (as indeed we all do) without noticing. It comes as a

genuine surprise to many of our Christian neighbours that there is anything in Judaism at all. I have just read Dr. Thouless's Authority and Freedom; and I find, after a discussion of definitions of Christianity which he finds unsatisfactory, the following:

'We have, however, one shortened statement of the Christian goal which has the authority of Jesus Christ himself: "Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul and with all thy strength, and with all thy mind; and thy neighbour as thyself" (Luke x, 27, A.V.). There is no over-simplification here. It is a programme so vast that we must all recognise our failure to attain it, so complex that all the references to Christian duties in the Gospels and other sacred writings can be regarded as amplifications of it. It is a great contribution of Kierkegaard to religious thought that he constantly reminds us of this goal of the Christian life, and invites us to measure the value of such religious accessories as creeds, ceremonials and rules of behaviour, by considering how far they lead us towards this goal and how far we have allowed them, instead, to become substitute goals.' (Authority and Freedom p.57)

It does not seem to occur to Dr. Thouless that what he is saying is pure and authentic Judaism through and through, although it is not, of course, Judaism entire.

9.

Let us now look at the question for a moment from the other side.

Apart from the more unworthy motives catalogued earlier, what is it in Christianity which attracts? I should guess two principal things: the first, the figure of Jesus; the second, what may be called summarily the sacramental character of Christianity.

(1) On the first I have said already that from our side we must learn to be able to acknowledge that Jesus was a great figure, a very great figure, even a transcendently great figure. But we should add that there have been others too, Buddha, Akmaton, Lao-Tze, Pythagoras,

Plato, Hillel, Maimonides, St. Francis, George Fox, Spinoza. It is not against the figure of Jesus, but against the claim that he is the one and only channel of approach to God, that we should register our definite and opposing opinion.

But even the view that the human Jesus is the one and only channel of approach to God is not yet Christianity. It might have been considered so a hundred years ago, say in the days of Seeley's Ecce Homo, though even at that time Renan lost his professorial chair because in his Inaugural Lecture he spoke of Jesus as an 'incomparable man'. No! Christianity is something more; and the would-be convert must be brought to understand this. Christianity is not, as Dr. Thouless (and as, perhaps, Henri Bergson) seems to think, just Judaism as taught by the hero of the early Gospels. Nor is it even the adoration of the man, Jesus. It is the worship of the man-God, Christ. This point is illustrated forcibly although crudely in the anecdote told of Talleyrand who, when asked by a man who wished to found a new religion how he should set about it, replied equably: 'First of all get yourself crucified, and then rise again on the third day'. But Talleyrand is, I suppose, out of date, so I quote The Times of 3 April 1954:

"Until recently there were influential writers who maintained that pure, original Christianity was what had been taught in the Sermon on the Mount and that this was subsequently perverted into a dark religion of death, called by Bernard Shaw 'Crosstianity'. More critical study of the New Testament leaves this theory with no support whatever. There never has been any Christianity which was not centred in the cross of Christ. The Gospels were written, as everyone now recognises, out of the faith and experience of the Churches founded by the apostolic mission. They lived in the light of Easter and Pentecost and the new creation wrought by the risen Christ."

I am not offering you this paragraph as an authoritative pronouncement

on the nature of Christianity - I am not competent to pass judgment on that - although it is certainly a representative one. I quote it in order to make it clear that 19th century humanitarianism is no longer to be taken as synonymous with Christianity. It can no longer be said, as Michon, the French priest and anti-clerical novelist, wrote in 1864: "All who adore God in spirit and truth are Christian in our eyes, no matter in what climate, civilization or cult." Very much to the contrary! Only a short while ago (15 October 1954) I listened on the radio to a sermon from the lips of no less a person than Monsignor Knox who, in his account of the Christian message, said simply: 'A woman, Mary, carried in her body, and then suckled, God.' I do not know whether, or how far, such a statement would be approved by other Christian thinkers, but the issue raised in it cannot be evaded. Our would-be convert should understand for his own sake that the word Christianity means something determinate. It means Christ-ianity, that is (in the words of the World Council of Churches) the 'acceptance of our Lord Jesus Christ as God and Saviour'.

10.

I come now to the second attraction in Christianity, what I have called its sacramental character. A Sacrament is defined in the Concise Oxford Dictionary as a 'religious ceremony or act regarded as outward and visible sign of inward and spiritual grace'. For the Christian, and in particular for the Roman Catholic, the year, and personal life, are marked throughout by such religious ceremonies; and whoever has been present at the celebration of the Mass, or has listened to the music composed for it

by the world's great musicians, will realise the strength of the attraction. And it is not only the ceremony, or the music, as such. It is not only what is said and done or sung on the specific occasion. It is the suggestion, the aroused feeling, the given conviction, that the whole world, and not this mere vessel, or that mere collection of words or sounds, is the vehicle of something higher. The universe is transfigured. The veil is lifted from the ordinary things of everyday life and some glimpse given of the reality beyond.

Here it seems to me that it is no use pretending to compete. Judaism has had no Bach; and in any case music and other stimulants to devotion are not encouraged in the traditional synagogue. Yet I wonder whether that is not part of its strength. Sentiment evaporates; emotions fade; enthusiasm dies away and needs constant reviving. The greatness of the ceremonial law is - and I am speaking quite seriously - that it is always with us. We need not accept the extravagances, certainly not the puerilities, of the mystical and Hasidic literature, in order to see the symbolic intention of much of it. The Bible itself affirms that the eating of unleavened bread on the Passover is a memorial of the deliverance from slavery, the dwelling in booths on Tabernacles of the dependance of man on God; while the Levitical Law of holiness invests everything we do, or abstain from doing, with a transcendental significance. The whole calendar of the Jewish year - and the Jewish month and the Jewish day - is in that sense sacramental, the 'outward and visible sign' of 'inward and spiritual grace.'

So too, is the root idea which lies at the bottom of the very existence of Jewry. This idea is the idea of dedication. Jewry is a

dedicated people; and it is, I think, on this rock that we must, now as ever, plant our flag. Our reply to Christianity and Christianising Jews can only be that ultimately Jesus is the son of God only in the sense in which all men are, according to the Jewish Bible, sons of God. There is a Rabbinic comment on the Shema I should have you meditate on: "The Lord our God, the Lord is one": upon us has his name been sanctified especially'. The difficulty is clear: if he is 'our' God, i.e., (apparently) exclusively ours, how can he be 'one', i.e., for all men? And the answer given is also clear: he is indeed God of all men, but we recognise him, that is, 'bear his name', more than do others.

Since God, however especially recognised by the Jews, is God of the whole world, he is not God for those of Jewish parents only. I always like to recall the letter written by that star of Rabbinic Jewry, the great Maimonides, to a convert to Judaism, who seems to have felt himself inferior to a Jew 'by blood' and who brought his trouble to the master. The master writes: 'Let not thy descent be light in thine eyes. If our descent is from Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, thy descent is from God himself; as is expressly stated in the book of Isaiah: "One shall say, I am the Lord's: another shall call himself by the name of Jacob."

You may think that this was only written personally to help an individual. But I draw your attention to a passage of the Code, the authoritative Mishneh Torah (Maimonides' Repetition of the Law) itself: "And why did not Levi have a share with his brethren in the inheritance of the land of Israel and the spoil? Because he was set apart to worship God and to serve him and to teach his upright ways and righteous judgments to the many. And not the tribe of Levi only, but any man born into the

world (the phrase used is the most general possible, literally, 'each single individual of all those who come into the world') whose spirit has moved him freely, and whose understanding has taught him to set himself apart and stand before God to serve him and worship him in order to know God; anyone who walks upright as God made him and has thrown off from his neck the yoke of the 'many inventions made by man' (Eccles. 7.29) - such a one is sanctified with the sanctity of the holy of holies, and God will be his portion and his inheritance for ever and unto all eternity".

11.

But I must here enter a caveat. Maimonides' requirements are severe. Traditional Jewish teaching has always turned its face against a 'soft' view of God. One is invited, or rather one is summoned, to 'walk in his way'; but the way is not offered as an easy one. Feeling is not enough. There is required of us as well both understanding and action. There is in Judaism no merely emotional and sentimental 'cuddling up to God'. I talked about the 'sacramentalism' of the Jewish way of life; but I should have you note most carefully that there is never a suggestion of absorption or participation in God, certainly not of identity with God. We participate, in the Rabbinic phrase, in the work of the Creator, not in the Creator. The Psalmist yearns to 'appear before God', not to disappear in God. Here even later Jewish mysticism, which went a very long way on paths most of us do not care to travel, called a halt; and it may be that in this too we part company with some Christians and must firmly declare our own stand. There is, and we should clearly know that there is, a Jewish mysticism; but its essential and finest expression is

not in the vagaries of the Kabbala, but in the Biblical book of Psalms.

12.

I have touched on some of the points of agreement and disagreement between Judaism and Christianity which the would-be convert should be asked to weigh. I think we may now go further. We should, I think, register our objection to the current habit of referring to western civilization as Christian. We should point out to the would-be convert that most of the teaching designated by that name is natively Jewish. The minimal proper phrase to be used to designate it is Judeo-Christian. I notice a tendency in some modern American Jewish writing to deprecate this term. The reason seems to be, so far as I can make out, 'national' pride. But there is a pride more justifiable than national pride, and that is the pride that one nation burst through the bounds of nationality and gave a way of life to the world at large. So in spite of objection I propose to insist on the term, particularly as it gives rise again to our main problem in a fresh and interesting way.

For if the term is accurate; if Judaism, through Christianity, has played so important a part in the making of modern western man; if the Jewish world-view, through Christianity, has become so profoundly absorbed into the common life around us - then, it may well be asked, and asked seriously: Why in Heaven's name should we continue to persist? The mission is performed; the function is effected. The matter is thus at an end. The play is over. We may leave the stage.

There are I think two answers to this. The first is simple, and painful to our neighbours; the second is difficult, and painful to

ourselves.

The first is that the message has not been taken in its purity. It has not been received as it was offered. The Jewish doctrine of God has been wrapped up by Christianity with an apparatus of theological dogma which is unacceptable to many, and which therefore proves a stumbling block to its acceptance. For that reason the pure doctrine still requires to be practised, and preached. Judaism in fact is not only an alternative to Christianity. It is, we venture to think, a preferable alternative.

The second answer, I fear, is for many of us unpleasant but it is none the less true. It is no use asking: Why persist? We cannot help it. Such is our destiny: we are the chosen people. We may have lost the sense of dedication. We may have lost the power to live up to ourselves. We may have abandoned our vocation, deserted our post. But whether we understand it or not, realise it or not, like it or not, the fact remains as it is. Willy, nilly, we have been chosen out of all the peoples, and willy, nilly, we shall have to put up with it.

'And that which cometh into your mind shall not be at all; in that ye say, We will be as the nations, as the families of the countries, to serve wood and stone. As I live, saith the Lord God, surely with a mighty hand, and with a stretched out arm, and with fury poured out, will I be king over you.'